The Relationship between Adaptation Disorders and Victimization among North Korean Defectors

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I. Introduction

1. Purpose of the Study

This study examines the relationship between adaptation disorders and the likelihood of victimization among North Korean defectors. By establishing hypotheses and collecting data for analysis, the research follows a nomothetic explanatory approach.

Specifically, this study considers the adaptation challenges North Korean defectors – whose numbers are expected to rapidly increase within South Korea - might experience upon their arrival. By exploring the causal and statistical relationships between these characteristics and crime victimization, this study aims to inform preventative measures against potential crimes against North Korean defectors. Ultimately, this work seeks to contribute to the successful integration of these defectors into South Korean society.

2. Background of study

This research stems from an interest in the human rights of North Korean residents and the situation of defectors. While studying for my undergraduate minor degree, I became curious about the misguided perceptions North Korean defectors may have been taught, and whether these misperceptions could have negative impacts as they integrate into South Korean society. My aim is to explore whether such impacts exist and, if so, to explore what could be done to support them.

II. Theoretical Background

1. Definition of Variables

The independent variable in this study is the adaptation disorders North Korean defectors may experience in South Korea. One example of such disorders discussed are sexual adaptation disorders. The dependent variable in this study is the crime victimization of North Korean defectors - the crime victimization experienced by North Korean defectors from the time of their entry into South Korea to the present. Crime victimization is defined as "the violation of one's life, body, or property through acts or omissions that contravene criminal law." In this context, such crimes encompass fraud, theft, robbery, assault, injury, sexual violence, and sexual harassment.

2. Labeling Theory

In labeling theory, *stigma* refers to accepting societal prejudices and stereotypes as societal norms, formed from an early age. In this case, North Korean defectors may have developed biased gender stereotypes under the influence of North Korean society from an early age. However, when they enter South Korean society, they may lack awareness of sexual crimes due to their distorted perceptions of gender, which can increase their vulnerability to crime victimization. Stigma hence influences the formation of negative self-perceptions or beliefs - if defectors repeatedly experience difficulties adapting to sexual norms in South Korea, they may develop a negative self-image. This can cause significant challenges and fear during their successful adaptation into South Korean society.

III. Methodology

1. Research Model and Hypothesis

The following research hypothesis was constructed based on crime theories and the results of previous studies. It posits that sexual adaptation challenges, resulting from difficulties adapting to new norms due to fixed stereotypes about masculinity and femininity, has a positive relationship with crime victimization. Based on this assumption, the hypothesis of this study is as follows:

Research Hypothesis: There is a positive correlation between sexual maladaptation, stemming from rigid gender norms as described in the *labeling model*, and the likelihood of crime victimization among North Korean defectors.

This hypothesis aims to verify whether the sexual adaptation challenges experienced by North Korean defectors have experienced influence their likelihood of crime victimization. In this study, sexual adaptation challenges serve as the independent variable within the labeling model, focusing on adaptation difficulties caused by fixed gender stereotypes. The study seeks to identify significant variables in the relationship between this independent variable and the dependent variable (crime victimization), comparing the relative influence of each.

2. Data Collection and Analysis Methods

This study uses secondary data from the Korean Institute of Criminology "Survey on Crime Victimization of North Korean Defectors" (2006). The survey features self-administered questionnaires with North Korean defectors aged 20 and above.

Data was conducted using R and SPSS 25.0 software, primarily through binary logistic regression analysis. The process involved the following steps:

1. Descriptive analysis and normality tests: These were conducted to examine general data characteristics and the distribution of key variables. Missing values were identified through descriptive and frequency analysis and coded accordingly.

2. Reliability and validity analyses: These were conducted to form a Likert scale of independent variables in the study's research hypothesis. For the dependent variable, crime victimization, reliability analysis was performed and Cronbach's alpha was calculated to assess validity.

3. Correlation analysis: This was carried out to analyze the relationship between the independent and dependent variables in this study.

4. Binary logistic regression analysis: This final step was conducted to quantitatively test the research hypothesis.

IV. Results

1. Verification of the Research Model

To examine the general characteristics of the main variables used in this study, a descriptive analysis was conducted. The response values for the three items used as independent variables in this study had minimum values of 1 and maximum values of 4, with results shown in Table 1.

Descriptive Analysis	Chastity	Adventurousness	Responsibility
Respondents	211	209	209
Mean	3.2559	3.0	2.7464
Median	3.0	3.0	3.0
Mode	3.0	3.0	3.0

Table 1: Survey results on gender attitudes among North Korean defectors (n≈210).

All items had mean, median, and mode values of approximately 3. Overall, the responses to these three items therefore indicate that North Korean defectors hold certain stereotypes about masculinity and femininity.

2. Normality Test

Based on the statistics above, a normality test was conducted for each item which results are shown in Figure 1.

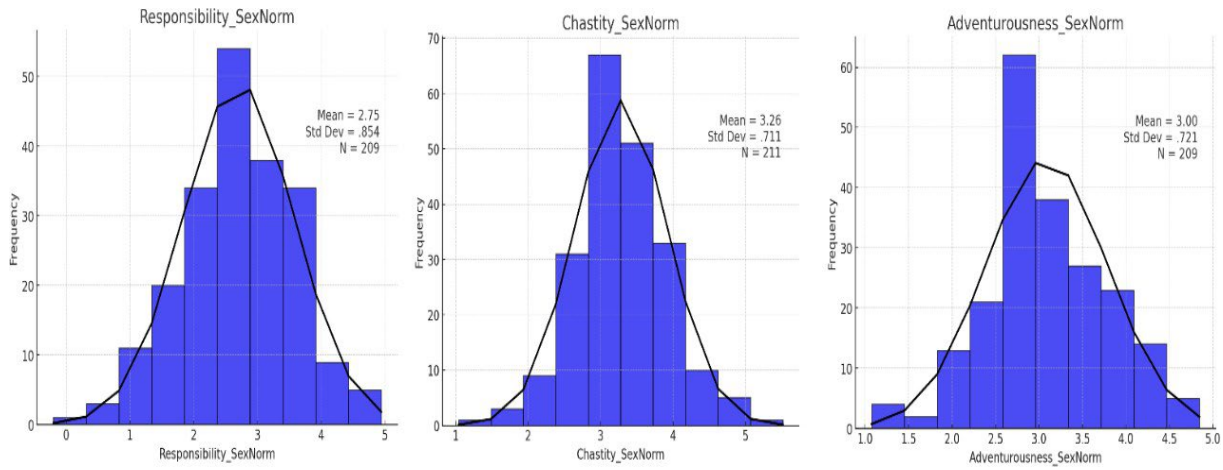

Figure 1: Normality testing results: All variables met criteria (skewness |<3|, kurtosis |<20|). 'Chastity': skewness 0.6, kurtosis 0.09; 'Men's Adventurousness': skewness 0.6, kurtosis 0.09; 'Responsibility of Women': skewness 0.1, kurtosis 0.6. Data satisfies normal distribution criteria.

3. Reliability and Validity Analysis

Based on the descriptive statistics and normality test, a Likert scale was constructed, and reliability and validity analyses were conducted. In Table 2, Cronbach's alpha is shown.

Reliability Statistics	
Cronbach's Alpha	Number of Items
0.444	3

Table 2: Cronbach's alpha value was 0.444, indicating that the reliability was not particularly high.

Cronbach's alpha is a method for assessing reliability, comparing the amount of shared variance (covariance), among the various items that comprise the total variance. The Cronbach's alpha value helps determine whether the responses to questions on chastity, adventurousness, and responsibility measure the same concept.

Additionally, KMO and Bartlett tests provide information on whether the correlations among variables are adequately explained by other variables. According to results of Table 3, they indicate good validity for the model.

KMO and Bartlett's Test		
KMO (Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin) Test		0.581
Bartlett's Test of Sphericity	Approximate Chi-Squared	27.163
	Degrees of Freedom	3
	p-value	0.01

Table 3: Validity analysis using the KMO and Bartlett tests showed a KMO measure of 0.581, with a significance level of 99%.

4. Analysis of Hypothesis

The proceeding correlation analysis was conducted to determine whether the relationships between the variables are significant. The results from Table 4 indicate that the relationships between crime victimization and the three variables are not significant.

Correlation Analysis		Crime Victim	Chastity	Adventurousness	Responsibility
Crime Victim	Pearson's r	1	0.039	0.016	0.006
	p-value		0.574	0.821	0.935
Chastity	Pearson's r	0.039	1	0.217	0.266
	p-value	0.574		0.002	0.000
Adventurousness	Pearson's r	0.016	0.217	1	0.156
	p-value	0.821	0.002		0.024
Responsibility	Pearson's r	0.006	0.266	0.156	1
	p-value	0.935	0.000	0.024	

Table 4: According to correlation analysis via the labeling model, the number of respondents ranged from 209 to 214. The correlation coefficient between "crime victimization" and "opinions on chastity" is 0.574, between "crime victimization" and "opinions on men's adventurousness" is 0.821, and between "crime victimization" and "opinions on women's responsibility" is 0.935.

The correlation in Table 5 represents the results of the correlation analysis between the final variable of sexual adaptation disorder and crime victimization. This indicates that it does not meet the 95% confidence level, showing no significant correlation.

Correlation Analysis		crime victimization	sexual adaptation disorder
crime victimization	Pearson's r	1	0.019
	p-value		0.780
sexual adaptation disorder	Pearson's r	0.019	1
	p-value	0.780	

Table 5: The correlation coefficient was 0.019, and the significance probability was 0.780.

The classification accuracy from Table 6 was 76.4%, exceeding the satisfactory threshold of 50%. This indicates the majority of defectors experiencing sexual adaptation disorder are not related to crime victimization.

Classification Table	.00	1.00	Classification
Crime Victimization	159	0	100.0
	49	0	0
Overall Percent			76.4

Table 6: Only 208 defectors were included in the analysis. Of these, 159 respondents answered "no crime victimization," while 49 respondents answered "crime victimization occurred."

The following section represents the overall test of model coefficients, indicating the usefulness of the logistic regression model, and it shows that the model's fit is low.

overall test of model coefficients	Chi-squared	degrees of freedom	Probability
	0.079	1	0.779

Table 7: The significance probability of the chi-squared test is 0.779.

Finally, the model summary represents the goodness of fit of the model. According to the results of Table 8, the logistic regression equation explains only 0.1% of the variance of the dependent variable.

Model Summary	-2 log likelihood	Cox and Snell R-squared	Nagelkerke R-squared
	227.027	0.000	0.001

Table 8: The -2 log-likelihood was 227.027, and Nagelkerke R-squared was measured at 0.001.

The Probability from the Hosmer and Lemeshow test shows fitness of the inferred model. It indicates that the probability of the model was 62.1% which means appropriate to infer.

Hosmer and Lemeshow test	Chi-squared	degrees of freedom	Probability
	2.633	4	0.621

Table 9: The significance probability from the Hosmer and Lemeshow test was measured at 0.621, with p>0.05.

These values indicate that the equation's variables show a positive relationship with maladaptation due to sexual ideology, suggesting that as individuals struggle to adapt to Korean society due to rigid sexual ideologies, the likelihood of becoming a crime victim increases. Specifically, for every 1-unit increase in maladaptation due to sexual ideology, the odds of becoming a crime victim increase by 1.091 times. However, since the 95% confidence level is not met, we can conclude the study's hypothesis is not statistically significant.

variables of the equation						
About Sexual Ideology	B	S.E	Wald	degrees of freedom	Probability	Exp(B)
	.088	.311	.079	1	.779	1.091
	95% confidence interval for Exp(B)					
	lower limit			Upper limit		
	.593			2.009		

Table 10: The Wald value was 0.079, and the significance probability was 0.079 (p>0.05).

V. Conclusion and Implications

1. Conclusion

Although the analysis results were statistically insignificant, policy recommendations are still warranted. Data suggests North Korean defectors struggle adapt to South Korean society, facing discrimination in South Korea, and some even regret leaving North Korea. Therefore, I propose policy recommendations to ensure their safety, happiness, and freedom from crime and discrimination.

Descriptive statistics indicate defectors' difficulties in adapting to South Korean language and culture, impacting their perception of South Korea and mental health. Persistent communication barriers and lifestyle challenges may increase isolation, vulnerability to mental health issues, and crime victimization risk. With deteriorating conditions inside North Korea likely to increase defector numbers, developing comprehensive strategies to support this unique demographic's social adaptation is crucial.

2. Limitations of the Study

This study faced limitations due to its small sample size (214 participants) and dated dataset (from 2006). Given the unique characteristics of North Korean defectors, who do not constitute a large portion of the population and are difficult to survey, having secondary data available is fortunate. However, it is regrettable that the study could not include a larger sample size of at least 250 or 400 for more accurate research. Additionally, since the data used are from 2006, we must acknowledge the degree of social adaptation among North Korean defectors might have changed over time, raising concerns the study might not be aligned with current trends.

3. Policy Recommendations

Although the analysis results were not statistically significant, this study aims to envision a harmonious society where North Korean defectors can settle smoothly. Accordingly, this paper propose two key recommendations:

1) Establishing One-on-One Networks for Social Adaptation

Building relationships between North Korean defectors and South Korean residents is a crucial factor in helping them adapt to South Korean society. Many defectors rely heavily on their own networks, which can lead to misinformation and isolation. To address this, establishing one-on-one mentoring systems will allow defectors to learn practical tips from locals on South Korean culture and daily life,

such as navigating real estate contracts or paperwork. This approach will support defectors' transitions from being labeled as defectors to being recognized as fully integrated residents.

2) Proper Sexual Ideology Education

This study shows that North Korean defectors often hold very conservative views on masculinity and femininity, which may differ from South Korean norms. While the standards for sexual ideology may vary, its important to educate defectors on South Korean gender equality and challenge fixed gender perceptions. This education would not only help defectors align with societal norms but also be effective as a tool for crime prevention, fostering smoother social and cultural adaptation.

4. Future Research Directions

Building on this thesis, I am eager to expand this study to include global refugees. By increasing the sample size, I aim to strengthen the reliability and validity of these findings. The scope may also extend beyond North Korean defectors to refugees from diverse backgrounds and nationalities, who often hold fixed perceptions of sexual ideology. My future research will analyze how maladaptive ideologies from refugees' home countries may increase their risk of crime victimization during adaptation. The goal is to find solutions that help refugees live more safely and securely in their new environments.

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